

# Rath Freehand

People in Strange Situations

Erratic Eye Games

© 2024 Erratic Eye Games. RATH RPG™ is a trademark of Erratic Eye Games.

### **Creative Commons License**

Rath RPG is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International (CC BY 4.0)

<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>

### **Acknowledgments & Attribution**

Rath RPG is based on Knave by Ben Milton, licensed under CC BY 4.0.

Original work: Knave © 2018 Ben Milton

Published by Erratic Eye Games

Thank you for playing Rath RPG!

# Rath Freehand

*People in strange situations.*

## What This Is

Rath Freehand is the whole of Rath in a dozen pages. Same dice, same stats, same maths — but no aptitude lists, no equipment catalogue, and nothing to read before you start.

You get a character in five minutes. You describe who they are in two or three words, and those words are the rules. A cop has a badge, a radio, and a pistol because *of course she does* — you don't look any of that up, you just write it down and start playing.

**This is a GM-facing game.** There is no table to consult when a player asks whether their character can do something. There is you, the fiction, and a d20. If that sounds like more work, it isn't — it's less. The rulebook stops being a thing you arbitrate against and becomes a thing you arbitrate with.

**Use it for:** one-shots, conventions, a setting you invented an hour ago, teaching someone their first RPG, a game where you don't yet know what genre you're in.

**Use full Rath instead if:** you want a long campaign with mechanical character growth, or your players like builds. Freehand deliberately gives up the build.

**Compatible with everything.** Freehand uses the same stats, the same DCs, the same damage scale, and the same injury table as the full game. You can run a published Rath adventure with Freehand characters, or drop a Freehand character into a full-Rath party, without converting anything.

## 1. The Basics

### Tests

When the outcome is uncertain and failure costs something, roll:

**d20 + stat ≥ 12**

That's the whole resolution system. **12** is the target for almost everything.

- **Natural 20** — critical success. Something extra goes right.
- **Natural 1** — critical failure. Something goes wrong.

In a fight, you roll against the target's **AC** instead of 12.

**Don't roll when you don't need to.** If there's no real chance of failure, or failure isn't interesting, the character just does it.

# The Six Stats

| Stat       | Used For                                         |
|------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| <b>STR</b> | Melee attacks, lifting, breaking, physical power |
| <b>DEX</b> | Ranged attacks, dodging, climbing, sneaking      |
| <b>INT</b> | Knowledge, technical work, magic, crafting       |
| <b>WIS</b> | Perception, tracking, navigation, noticing       |
| <b>CON</b> | Toughness, resisting harm, healing               |
| <b>CHA</b> | Persuasion, deception, intimidation, charm       |

Whichever stat best fits what the player described is the one they add. If two stats both fit, let them use the better one.

# The Advantage Scale

Every test sits somewhere on four steps:

**Impossible → Disadvantage → Straight Roll → Advantage**

| Step                 | Roll              | When                                                 |
|----------------------|-------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Impossible</b>    | No roll           | No training, no tools, or it simply can't be done    |
| <b>Disadvantage</b>  | 2d20, take lower  | Bad conditions, injured, working against your nature |
| <b>Straight Roll</b> | 1d20              | The default                                          |
| <b>Advantage</b>     | 2d20, take higher | A keyword applies, good tools, clever approach       |

Each factor moves you **one step**. Factors in the same direction don't stack — you can't get double advantage. Factors in opposite directions cancel one-for-one.

This scale is where keywords live. See Section 3.

# Fortune

Every character has **Fortune**, maximum 3. Start each session with 1. Gain 1 on a natural 20. The GM hands them out for good play.

**Spend 1 Fortune to:** - Reroll any test and keep the better result - Help an ally's roll, if you can describe how you're in position to - **Declare something true** that one of your keywords makes plausible (see Section 3)

## 2. Making a Character

Five minutes, four steps, no lists.

### Step 1 — Say who they are

One sentence. “A tired homicide detective three weeks from retirement.” “A void-station welder who’s never seen a planet.” “The youngest daughter of a burned-out noble house.”

### Step 2 — Pick 3 keywords

Pull them out of the sentence. The detective is **Police, Homicide Detective, Burned Out**. See Section 3 for what makes a good one.

### Step 3 — Assign stats

Distribute **3, 2, 2, 1, 1, 0** across the six stats. Highest goes where the concept points.

*Rolling instead:* 3d6 per stat in order, take the **lowest die** of each. Then swap any two.

### Step 4 — Derive and equip

|              |                   |
|--------------|-------------------|
| <b>HP</b>    | 10 + CON          |
| <b>AC</b>    | 10 + DEX + armour |
| <b>Slots</b> | 10 + CON          |

Then take **whatever your keywords obviously imply**, plus **three things you name**. The detective has a badge, a radio, cuffs, and a pistol without asking. Then she says: a photo of her daughter, a hip flask, and a lockpick set she isn’t supposed to own.

The GM says yes, or says “not that, but you could have —”. That’s the entire equipment system. Section 4 covers the few things that need numbers.

**Write it on an index card.** Name, three keywords, six stats, HP, AC, what you’re carrying, Fortune. That’s a character sheet.

## 3. Keywords

Keywords are the only special-ability system in Freehand. Everything an aptitude, class, or feat would do in another game, a keyword does here.

A keyword is **two or three words describing something true about your character**. Not a stat, not a power — a fact. *Police. Grew Up On The Docks. Wanted In Three Counties. Ex-Wyvern Rider. Very Large.*

They do three things.

# They grant permission

This is the important one. A keyword can move a test from **Impossible** to a roll.

Without the **Locksmith** keyword, you don't get to attempt the vault's deadbolt — you have no idea what you're looking at. With it, you roll. Without **Police**, you can't talk your way past a crime-scene cordon at all; with it, you're arguing with a colleague.

This is what makes a character with four keywords different from one with two. Not a bigger bonus — a **wider world of things they're allowed to try**. Depth is capped. Breadth isn't.

# They grant advantage

When a keyword is clearly relevant to a roll you were already going to make, you get **advantage**. One step, once. A second applicable keyword adds nothing mechanically.

The player argues for it: *"I'm a Homicide Detective — I've stood over a hundred bodies. I should have advantage reading this scene."* The GM says yes or no. Say yes often.

# They let you declare

**Spend 1 Fortune** to declare a fact the world now contains, if one of your keywords makes it plausible.

*"I'm Police. There's a patrol car parked on this block — there always is."* *"I Grew Up On The Docks. I know a way through the fence."* *"I'm Wanted In Three Counties. One of these guards has my face on a poster, and he's nervous about it."*

The GM can narrow it, but shouldn't refuse it outright — if the keyword makes it plausible, the Fortune point has bought it. This is how a player writes the setting with you.

# What makes a good keyword

The test is **how often it comes up**.

| Too broad      | Too narrow              | About right         |
|----------------|-------------------------|---------------------|
| Adventurer     | Left-Handed Lockpicking | Thief               |
| Skilled        | Allergic To Cats        | Ship's Doctor       |
| Strong         | Speaks Old High Vessin  | Raised By Wolves    |
| Good At Things | Once Met The Duke       | Owes The Duke Money |

Broad keywords apply to everything, so they stop meaning anything. Narrow ones never come up. Aim for something that'll matter two or three times a session.

**Downsides count.** *Burned Out*, *Blind*, *Hunted*, *Terrible Liar* are all excellent keywords. They grant permission and advantage in their own strange directions — being blind is an asset in the dark, being hunted means you know how the hunters think — and they earn Fortune when they cost you something. A keyword that only ever helps is a boring keyword.

# Keywords change

This is not a character sheet you fill in once.

**Gain one** when the story earns it. Survive a month in the marshes and you might take *Marsh-Wise*. Kill something famous and *Dragonslayer* is now true about you, for better and worse.

**Lose one** when the story takes it. Get struck off and *Police* is gone — though *Ex-Police* is a different and sometimes better keyword.

**Swap one** during any rest or scene break, if the fiction supports it.

**Keep it to three active** at a time. A character can *be* many things; three of them are load-bearing this session. Let players reshuffle which three between sessions.

**GM:** when a player invokes a keyword you don't think applies, don't say "no." Say "what does being *Police* have to do with this lock?" Half the time they have an answer you didn't think of, and it's better than the one you'd have given.

## 4. Gear

There is no equipment list. There's a scale, and the GM prices things against it.

### Weapons

Pick a damage die. That's the weapon.

| Damage | Slots | What it is                                               |
|--------|-------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| d4     | 1     | Improvised. A chair leg, a rock, a letter opener         |
| d6     | 1     | Small or one-handed. Knife, club, pistol, hatchet        |
| d8     | 2     | The standard. Sword, axe, rifle, spear                   |
| d10    | 3     | Heavy, or needs both hands. Greatsword, shotgun, poleaxe |

Then take **one trait free**. Each extra trait costs **+1 slot, or one step down the damage die**.

| Trait                | Effect                                          |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Ranged (near)</b> | Attack to near distance, using DEX              |
| <b>Ranged (far)</b>  | Attack to far distance, using DEX               |
| <b>Reload</b>        | Action to reload after a few shots              |
| <b>Piercing</b>      | Ignores 2 AC                                    |
| <b>Throwable</b>     | Can be thrown to near                           |
| <b>Concealable</b>   | Hidden under clothing, no test                  |
| <b>Quiet</b>         | Doesn't give away your position                 |
| <b>Burst</b>         | Two targets in near range, both at disadvantage |

**Worked example — a pistol.** Start at d8 (a standard weapon, 2 slots). Ranged (near) is the free trait. Concealable costs one step down: **d6, ranged, concealable, 2 slots**. Want it to hit harder? Give up concealable and it's a d8. Want it in one slot? Drop to d4 or spend the slot elsewhere.

**Worked example — a sniper rifle.** d10, two-handed, 3 slots. Free trait: ranged (far). Add *piercing* and *quiet* — that's two extra traits, so either +2 slots (5 total, it's an enormous thing in a case) or step the damage down twice to d6 (a small, quiet, armour-piercing weapon that doesn't hit hard). Pick the one that matches the fiction.

**d10 is the ceiling.** Nothing a person picks up and uses does more than d10 without paying for it — a round spent aiming, an ammunition limit, a keyword requirement, or simple rarity. Break this and the weapon becomes the character.

## Armour

| Armour        | AC | Slots | Notes                                                   |
|---------------|----|-------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Light</b>  | +1 | 2     | Leather, a padded coat, a concealed vest                |
| <b>Medium</b> | +2 | 3     | Mail, a flak jacket. Disadvantage on stealth            |
| <b>Heavy</b>  | +3 | 5     | Plate, a hardsuit. Disadvantage on stealth and swimming |
| <b>Shield</b> | +1 | 1     | Can be destroyed to absorb up to 15 damage              |
| <b>Helmet</b> | +1 | 1     |                                                         |



Whatever the setting calls it, it's one of these five.

## Everything else

Write it down. **One slot each.** You have 10 + CON slots.

Don't price it. Don't track coins unless money is what the game is about — and if it is, invent a unit and charge what feels right. Nobody has ever had a better session because the rope cost 1 silver.

## Things that run out

Ammunition, torches, rations, medical supplies, fuel — anything you'd rather not count. Give it a **usage die** and roll it when it's used:

**d20 → d12 → d10 → d8 → d6 → d4 → gone**

On a **1 or 2**, the die shrinks one step. When a d4 comes up 1 or 2, you're out.

Roll ammunition once after each fight. Roll light sources every hour. Roll everything else when it'd be tense.

## 5. Playing

### Combat

**Initiative:** every round, each player rolls **d20 + DEX vs 12**. Success means they go before the enemies; failure means after. Reroll each round.

Order: players who passed → enemies → players who failed.

**Faster:** roll 1d6. On 1-3 the enemies go first, on 4-6 the players do.

**Your turn:** move up to **near** and take an action, or **run** up to **far** and do nothing else.

**Attack:** d20 + STR (melee) or DEX (ranged) vs the target's AC.

**Damage:** roll the weapon's die, add STR if it's melee. **Max roll explodes** — roll again and add, and keep going while you keep rolling max.

**Natural 20:** the target loses 1 AC for the rest of the fight. **Natural 1:** something goes wrong. GM decides what.

**Two weapons:** after your first attack, take a second at disadvantage. **Stunts** — shove, disarm, trip, grapple: opposed test, usually STR vs STR or DEX vs DEX. **Reactions:** one per round. Attack an enemy who leaves your reach, or throw yourself in front of an ally.

# Distance

| Range   | Roughly                             |
|---------|-------------------------------------|
| Close   | Arm's length. Melee                 |
| Near    | Across a room. One move             |
| Far     | Across a street. A run              |
| Distant | Further. Not part of this fight yet |

# Getting hurt

**At 0 HP:** roll **CON vs 12**. Pass and you get 1d6 HP and stay up on adrenaline. Fail and you're down — you can crawl, nothing else, until the danger's over.

**When the danger passes, roll 2d6:**

|       |                                                  |
|-------|--------------------------------------------------|
| 2d6   |                                                  |
| 2-3   | <b>Dead.</b> Make the last words count           |
| 4-6   | <b>Maimed.</b> Something permanent. +1d6 HP      |
| 7-9   | <b>Broken.</b> A week off your feet. +1d6 HP     |
| 10-11 | <b>Battered.</b> A day. +1d6 HP                  |
| 12    | <b>Tough bastard.</b> +2d6 HP, back on your feet |

A maiming is a new keyword. *One Eye. Bad Leg. Ruined Hand.* Write it down.

# Resting

**Short rest** — an hour somewhere reasonably safe: recover **1d6 + CON** HP. **Long rest** — a night somewhere actually safe: back to full.

# Getting better

Freehand has no levels by default. Characters change by **gaining and losing keywords**, and that's usually enough — a one-shot doesn't need an XP economy.

If you're running it longer and want progression, use this and nothing else:

**After each session, one of:** raise a stat by 1 (max 6), or take a fourth keyword slot (max 5 total). That's it. Roll 1d6 and add it to your max HP every third session if the players want to feel sturdier.

# 6. Dials

Set these before session one. Say them out loud so the table agrees.

**Lethality.** The default is dangerous — a d8 to the chest is a third of a starting character. To go *deadlier*, drop starting HP to **5 + CON**. To go *pulpier*, let players spend Fortune to negate a hit entirely.

**Guns.** The scale above treats a pistol as a d6 and a rifle as a d8, which puts them level with a knife and a sword. That looks wrong at first — surely a rifle beats a longbow — but

damage isn't where firearms win. They win on **traits**: a bow spends its one free trait just getting to far range, while a rifle gets there and can still afford *piercing* (armour was built for arrows, not bullets), *burst*, or *quiet* with a suppressor. Two weapons, the same die, and the gun is doing three things the bow can't. That's the distinction, and the scale already carries it.

If you want firearms frightening on top of that, shift **every** gun up one die and give non-ballistic armour no AC against them. Apply it to the enemies too — that's the whole point.

**Grit.** For survival games, start every consumable one usage die lower than you otherwise would, and require a ration on any day of hard travel.

**Magic and the strange.** There are no spell lists here. If a character is a wizard, *Wizard* is their keyword: it grants permission to attempt magical things and advantage when doing them, and the roll is INT vs 12. Failure should cost something — describe what. If you want an actual magic system, that's what full Rath's *Advanced Magic* is for, and it drops straight in.

**Session zero in one question.** Ask each player: “*what's the worst thing that could plausibly happen to your character?*” Write the answers down. That's your adventure.

## Quick Reference

**Test:**  $d20 + \text{stat} \geq 12$ . Nat 20 crit, nat 1 fumble. **Attack:**  $d20 + \text{STR/DEX} \geq \text{AC}$ . Damage explodes on max. **Advantage:** Impossible → Disadvantage → Straight → Advantage. One step per factor, no stacking, opposites cancel. **Keywords:** 3 active. Grant permission, grant advantage, and — for 1 Fortune — let you declare a fact. **Fortune:** max 3. Reroll, help an ally, or declare. Start each session with 1, gain on a nat 20. **Weapons:**  $d4/d6 = 1$  slot,  $d8 = 2$ ,  $d10 = 3$ . One trait free, extras cost a slot or a die step.  $d10$  is the ceiling. **Armour:** Light +1 / Medium +2 / Heavy +3 / Shield +1 / Helmet +1. **Carrying:**  $10 + \text{CON}$  slots. One slot per item unless it's obviously bigger. **HP:**  $10 + \text{CON}$ . **AC:**  $10 + \text{DEX} + \text{armour}$ . **At 0 HP:** CON vs 12 to stay up. Then  $2d6$  on the injury table. **Rest:** short =  $1d6 + \text{CON}$ . Long = full. **Usage die:**  $d20 \rightarrow d12 \rightarrow d10 \rightarrow d8 \rightarrow d6 \rightarrow d4 \rightarrow \text{gone}$ . Shrinks on a 1-2.

## The Character Card

|                           |           |       |         |         |              |
|---------------------------|-----------|-------|---------|---------|--------------|
| NAME                      |           |       | concept |         |              |
| KEYWORDS                  | 1         |       | 2       |         | 3            |
| STR                       | ___       | DEX   | ___     | INT     | ___          |
|                           |           | WIS   | ___     | CON     | ___          |
|                           |           | CHA   | ___     |         |              |
| HP                        | ___ / ___ | AC    | ___     | FORTUNE | ○ ○ ○        |
| CARRYING (10 + CON slots) |           |       |         |         |              |
| _____                     |           | _____ |         | _____   |              |
| _____                     |           | _____ |         | _____   |              |
| _____                     |           | _____ |         | _____   |              |
| _____                     |           | _____ |         | _____   |              |
| WEAPON                    | _____     |       | dmg d   | ___     | traits _____ |

ARMOUR \_\_\_\_\_ + \_\_\_\_\_ AC

*Rath Freehand is part of the Rath RPG family. For aptitudes, spell lists, character advancement, and the full equipment catalogue, see the Rath RPG Players Handbook.*